Personal Budget Snapshot

For deciding how much of the practice startup I can self-fund without touching the emergency-fund plan.

Monthly picture

Line	Amount
Take-home (after tax + 401k)	$4,250
Total monthly outlays	~$2,991
Monthly surplus	~$1,259
Standing transfer to emergency fund	~$786
Residual after that transfer	~$473

Outlays detail

Category	Amount
Rent	$1,285
Utilities	$155
Car payment	$340
Auto insurance	$95
Groceries	$300
Dining out	$120
Gas	$80
Phone	$55
Health insurance	$360
Subscriptions + misc	$161
Niece + incidentals	$40
Total	~$2,991

Reserves and goals

- Liquid savings: $14,500 at Buckeye Federal Credit Union.
- Emergency-fund goal: $20,000 by end of 2026, roughly $786 a month gets there.
- 401k: about $28,000, contributing 6 percent with a 4 percent employer match.
- Credit: Discover paid in full monthly, score around 755.
- Renter's insurance quoted at $12 a month for $30K contents, not yet purchased.

Six-month savings trajectory (if nothing changes)

Month	Emergency fund transfer	Running emergency balance
Jan 2027	$786	(2026 goal already met, redirecting surplus)
Feb 2027	$786	building buffer
Mar 2027	$786 + bonus reconciliation	annual bonus lands in March
Apr 2027	$786	steady
May 2027	$786	steady
Jun 2027	$786	steady

Practice funding scenarios

The question is whether the startup spend fits inside the roughly 473 dollars a month residual, or whether it needs staging.

Scenario	Up-front outlay	Monthly recurring	Fits residual?
Bare minimum to open	~$650 one-time	~$110 / mo	yes, comfortably
Full recommended setup	~$1,300 one-time	~$150 / mo	yes if the one-time is staged over 2-3 months
Everything incl. optional	~$2,400 one-time	~$180 / mo	only by dipping into savings, not recommended

Read: the practice can be opened out of the monthly residual without touching the emergency fund, as long as the one-time costs are staged across a couple of months rather than paid all at once. The optional extras (laptop reserve, launch ads, brand polish) wait until the first client revenue lands.

Rule I am keeping: no month cuts the 786 dollar emergency-fund transfer to fund the practice, and nothing over 150 dollars gets bought without me approving it first.